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In just a matter of a few weeks we'll move into a new year. For those of us in the world of education, it traditionally marks the halfway point of the school year. Though everyone else has their minds on starting from scratch, we're in the thick of things. For many forensic coaches, now is the time of year when you address what's working with your team and what exactly isn't.

A little introspection never hurt anyone.

Challenge your students to pick up the pace as we move down the stretch toward state tournaments, qualifiers, and (they'll be here before you know it) Nationals. The first semester doesn't really matter any more. Come January, you'll be rested and ready to go.

Okay, maybe the sense of renewal the new year brings isn't really all that different between forensicators and the real world.

That could very well be a first.

Best of luck as your season continues! It is my that 2007 is filled with fun adventure for both you and your program.

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

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Thrift

by Daschle Stephens

Humiliation has always played an integral part in self-discovery, and I suppose my life is no different. In my high school Intro to Drama class – we had to go around the room and introduce ourselves by telling everyone what animal we were most like. The other guys were panthers. They were grizzlies, lions, eagles, and boa constrictors – they were beasts of power, strength, and virility. Me? I was a squirrel. So while every other turbo-testosterone charged teen male was on the prowl – I was left open to a barrage of hi-larious innuendos about my "nuts". It never got old.

Now in my own defense, the squirrel thing isn't as asinine as it may sound. Growing up, money was tight around my house. We were by no means starving, but we had a healthy appreciation for what we had. Much like squirrels, my younger brother, Kevin, and I were always on the lookout to gather resources for home. If we were good during the week, my mom would take the two of us out to McDonald's for a family dinner on Friday. After finishing our Happy Meals, my brother and I would make sure to grab extra salt, pepper, and packets of "fancy ketchup" to take home for future dinners. At age 8 this ritual is charming and endearing. At age 28 you're called cheap by merciless friends and coworkers – to which I always respond, "Back off – my meatloaf is now delicious *and* fancy."

Sundays were always spent diving through the paper for the coupons and sale sections. Eventually my brother and I would create games to make the task of bargain hunting for mom a little more enjoyable. Sometimes we would compare products at different stores to see who had the best deals, and to make the stakes more interesting: the one with the lower price gave the other an Indian Sunburn or during the holidays – a delightful Texas Tittie Twister. Scissors askew - we flew like starving junkyard dogs through the sections. Kevin had an eye for office supplies and clothing sales but I always delivered a weekly whooping when it came to frozen foods and produce. Working two jobs to make ends meet, my mom appreciated the help though she never really saw the need to spend money on the frivolous things that kids find to be the most important. Case in point – neither Kevin nor I ever had a real lunchbox. And by real, I do mean the plastic box with a cartoon or action hero on the front. Mom figured that the plastic bags that we brought home our groceries in worked just fine. This never really bothered me, but it always seemed to irritate the other kids at school who felt the need to show off: A). The lunchboxes that their parents bought them and B). The unforgiving physics the thin bag had on my chips when met with someone's balled up fist before walking to the bathroom.

It was at this point that I usually emptied the contents of a packet of "fancy ketchup" into one of their open cans of Dr. Pepper. The projectile vomiting that followed would ensure the safety of my chips in the future. But this didn't stop my mom from trying to stencil Optimus Prime on my grocery bag the next day out of guilt.

*

If being thrifty made me the weird kid – it has also made me an awkward adult. As I move grudgingly through the end of my 20's, I still have the charm of Beaver Cleaver in the throes of puberty. My hair cowlicks in angles not found in advanced geometry classes, my clothes are so far from being name brand that the tags are blank, I can never find anything witty to say and I laugh like Pee-Wee Herman. Ladies…control yourselves. One good thing to come of my money conscious upbringing was the ability to crunch numbers freakishly well resulting in a passion for mathematics and yet another way to drive away the opposite sex. These days I work as a computer programmer at a faceless corporation. Sure, there are the same predator archetypes in the work place as there were in high school – but for every squirrel there are a dozen lions and panthers ready to bust my bushy behind into submission. There's a reason why you don't see many squirrels

Saving Face

by Trevor Anders

SCENE 1

MIKE. Good evening ma'am. You look like you could use a makeover.

SUZIE. Excuse me?

MIKE. What I uh...I meant to say was you look like a beautiful lady who never has to worry about her appearance, but what if I told you that Lucky You Cosmetics could make you look even more glamorous?

SUZIE. I'd say I'm going out for dinner in an hour and I really need to finish getting ready.

MIKE. Please...I'll only take a moment of your time.

SUZIE. All right, just make it quick.

MIKE. You have a really nice place.

SUZIE. Thanks. I'm going to finish up here, so you just go on and give your pitch and I'll brush my teeth.

MIKE. Um...ok. Lucky You Cosmetics is the makeup for today's modern woman. Whether she is business or casual, at home or at play, we have the perfect style for you. Take this mascara. We guarantee three times your natural lashes.

SUZIE. (*gurgles and spits*) Really? Do you mind if I give it a try?

MIKE. Yeah, sure. Be my guest.

SUZIE. It's not bad.

MIKE. That was actually our first choice for the fall campaign but we went with something a little bolder.

SUZIE. And what's that?

MIKE. It's really not bad. (*laughs*)

SUZIE. I'm sorry, but I don't have much time so I'll take the mascara, this lipstick and that compact of eye shadow.

MIKE. Awesome Autumn. My personal favourite. That'll be thirty-five dollars. And here's my business card in case you would like to make any future purchases.

SUZIE. Now if I can just show you to the door

MIKE. By the way, have a nice date.

SUZIE. Excuse me?

MIKE. I said have a nice date.

SUZIE. How did you know I was going a date?

MIKE. It's the shoes. See, if you were going to grab a carton of take-out food, you would have worn some flats or loafers that you could kick off when you got home. I f you were going out with female friends for drinks, you would have worn boots. But you're wearing heels with some toe cleavage. Those are first date shoes. (*She stands, mouth agape*) That and a guy in a BMW just pulled in your driveway. (*beat of silence*) Okay! I'll just be seeing my way out.

SUZIE. Sure thing...

MIKE. Mike.

SUZIE. Thanks, Mike.

SCENE 2

MIKE. (*typing up invoice*) Suzanne Moore. Hmm... Well, not exactly what you'd call a model. Ok, but not great. (*holding up makeup*) It'd take more of this stuff than you could afford to make you gorgeous, but hey, another day another dollar. (*phone rings*) Hello, Lucky You Cosmetics, helping you put your best face forward for over thirty years, this is Mike. How can I help you?

SUZIE. Michael?

MIKE. Yeah, this is Mike.

SUZIE. Well, this is Suzanne Moore. I bought some makeup from you the other day.

MIKE. Right, the chick with the date.

SUZIE. Chick?

MIKE. Sorry. The woman with the social engagement.

SUZIE. Yes. Listen, I know…I know I shouldn't be calling you at this hour. And (*awkward laugh*) you're sort of a complete and total stranger…but I was wondering if you could help me out.

MIKE. What's wrong, did you run out of lip liner? 'Cause I can be right over there with my stuff in no time.

SUZIE. It's a little more serious than that. It's sort of been the worst night EVER. See…I've been scatter-brained at work this week and thought I'd go out and have a couple of drinks to blow off steam. No big deal, right?

MIKE. …right…

SUZIE. So I park my car in what I would later find out is a tow-away zone but not before I have a couple of beers and find that my purse has been stolen along with my wallet with all my cash and the keys to my car which, conveniently enough has been towed. So I have no money for a cab.

MIKE. Why don't you call one of your friends? Or your family?

SUZIE. As sad as this sounds – I'm new to the area. My family lives in Denver – and the people I know have unlisted numbers. All my contact information is in my cell phone – which was stolen with my purse.

MIKE. Hey, I'm sorry. I just sell makeup. I'm not a knight in shining armor. How did you get my number?

SUZIE. I found your business card in my jacket pocket. Help me out here...I just need a ride to my apartment and my landlord will let me in.

MIKE. I'd love to, honest, but…

SUZIE. Please.

MIKE. All right…geeze, have you ever considered a career in sales?

SUZIE. Oh! Thank you thank you thank you. I'm in front of Spencer's. It's on twenty-third. You know the place?

MIKE. Yeah. I'll be there in twenty minutes.

SCENE 3

MIKE. What the hell am I getting myself into here? Geeze, Mikey Boy you must be getting desperate. Maybe she'll, at least, buy some more makeup. Suzanne?

SUZIE. Mike? I really didn't think you'd show. I usually don't just call up random men with my problems.

MIKE. Oh, hey, it's not a problem. You know, several of my female friends call me their not-gay-gay-best-friend.

SUZIE. You're not gay?

MIKE. At last check, uh, no.

SUZIE. So. A make-up salesman. How's that working out for you?

MIKE. Actually, it's "Cosmetic Representative" and it's very lucrative, thank you very much.

SUZIE. Really?

MIKE. Really.

SUZIE. How's that?

MIKE. I understand women.

SUZIE. (*laughs*) Oh. Please go on. Do tell.

MIKE. Look, there are two reasons why women wear make-up. One: to feel more confident in their physical appearance and Two: to feel more attractive to the opposite sex. Or the same sex. Whatever. Now, be honest, whose opinion are you more interested in: some woman who is a complete stranger driving a pink Buick who only sees you as another

$30 as she says, “Oh, sweetie that lip gloss is just fabulous on you!” or…a random man you could potentially see yourself dating turning to you saying, “You look absolutely beautiful”.

SUZIE. (*beat*) What a load of crap.

MIKE. What?

SUZIE. Isn’t that a little stereotypical? Playing on desperation?

MIKE. Hey – she feels better about herself and has her ego stroked, meanwhile, I make a sale and have my wallet stroked. It’s a win-win situation, Suzie.

SUZIE. Uh-huh.

MIKE. I sense skepticism.

SUZIE. Yep.

MIKE. You question the humanitarian efforts of a Lucky You Cosmetic Representative?

SUZIE. Listen, Mother Theresa, I understand you’ve got to push products in order to pay the rent. That’s fine. I just think you’re exploiting lonely women... Besides, I doubt your little sales strategy is even all that effective.

MIKE. (*gasps*) What?!

SUZIE. (*laughs*) Yeah…I said it.

MIKE. She dares question the master at work?

SUZIE. The gauntlet has been thrown down.

MIKE. She – who not only purchased, but called me back?

SUZIE. I’m an exception. I was in a rush to go out on the date that never was – and I didn’t have time to sit down and listen to your pitch. I have time now. I’m sitting. Fire away. Champ.

MIKE. Oh…you have *no idea* what you’re in for. Okay. Give me a sec. I wasn’t prepared. Ah. Okay. Alright. Ready. Ready. Good evening ma’am. Lucky You Cosmetics is the make-up for today’s modern woman. Whether she is…

SUZIE. You said that the first time.

MIKE. I know. I’m getting warmed up.

SUZIE. And I’m cooling off. You’d better heat things up faster or you’ll lose the sale.

MIKE. Argh. Just play along, okay?

SUZIE. (*sighs*) Fine.

MIKE. Did I come over at a bad time?

SUZIE. Actually – yes. I was getting dressed and ready to go out.

MIKE. Really? Who were you about to go out with?

SUZIE. A guy.

MIKE. Anybody special?

SUZIE. Ha. Not anymore.

MIKE. C’mon.

SUZIE. Sorry. Yes. He’s very special. One of a kind.

MIKE. Are you excited?

SUZIE. I was. (*he looks at her*) I mean, yes. I can barely contain myself.

MIKE. Where are the two of you going?

SUZIE. Dinner and a movie. Typical date.

MIKE. Well, your dress is beautiful.

SUZIE. (*looks down, starts to soften a bit*) You think so?

MIKE. Yeah. I mean, (*laughs*) I’m trying to be professional right now but its sort of difficult, it’s just, you know, the color and the shape of the dress, they just…they look really nice on you.

SUZIE. Oh, uh, thanks.

MIKE. Yeah. Are you going to see a comedy?

SUZIE. No. Some action flick he picked out.

MIKE. I’m sure you’ll have a good time. He probably wanted something to get the adrenaline pumping.

SUZIE. Maybe so.

MIKE. Listen, I know we just met and all – but can I give you a piece of advice. You know, from a guy?

SUZIE. Sure.

MIKE. My manager would kill me for saying this – but us guys – we don't notice all the make-up. For most women – it's not even really necessary. Like you – you're naturally pretty. (*reaches for her face*) You – you don't need all this eyeliner and shadow. This dark lipstick – it's not you.

SUZIE. It's not?

MIKE. Nah. All you need is a little bit of moisturizer, some blush, and a light gloss on the lips. Just your charming self – and any guy in his right mind couldn't help but want to lean in and...(*leans in close to her face*)

SUZIE. ...and?

MIKE. (*whispers*) Any more doubt about my sales pitch?

SUZIE. Oh...you're good.

SCENE 4

(*Suzie enters Mike's office as he picks up the phone.*)

MIKE. Hello, Lucky You Cosmetics: Helping you put your best face forward for thirty years, this is Mike, how can I help you? Uh huh. Uh huh. Sure. Yep. I'll take care of that. Thanks. You too. Bye.

SUZIE. Well, well, well.

MIKE. Yes?

SUZIE. That's a nice little phone greeting you've got going for you.

MIKE. How are you?

SUZIE. Good. Good. You know – I came in to work today and found a dozen roses on my desk. Compliments of my "Friendly neighborhood Lucky You Cosmetics Representative" thanking me for being such a, quote, "charming and loyal customer for the past six months".

MIKE. (laughs) We like to take care of our clientele base.

SUZIE. I can tell. Mary Kay never went this far. Clinique bought me tickets to the opera, but...

MIKE. Clinique is just a bunch of show offs. We at Lucky You prefer more intimate expressions of our appreciation.

SUZIE. So I've noticed.

MIKE. Indeed.

SUZIE. So how are things going? Pushing truck loads of moisturizer?

MIKE. You know it.

SUZIE. Look, I wanted to stop by your office on the way home to see if you wanted to come out to the bar with me and some of my girlfriends tonight. I'd love for them to meet you.

MIKE. Oooh. I don't know, Suze. I'd rather just stay home this time.

SUZIE. We've stayed home for weeks. C'mon. My old roommate is in town. We never go out.

MIKE. I know. I'm tired. That's all.

SUZIE. You've been tired for *weeks*.

MIKE. It's not you, hon.

SUZIE. Yeah, well it gets a little frustrating when I have to drag you by your fingernails to go out in public with me.

MIKE. Listen, things are just incredibly busy right now – I've been working overtime in my sales region to try and meet last year's figures. Just...I dunno...give me some time. Let me relax. I promise. We'll go out somewhere real nice in the near future.

SUZIE. If you say so.

MIKE. Promise.

SUZIE. Okay.

MIKE. Bye hon.

SUZIE. Bye, Mike.

SCENE 5

SUZIE. (*on phone*) Hey Christie. Yeah, it's me…Suzie. I know. I know. I'm sorry. I don't think I'm going to meet up with you girls tonight. I know Lisa's only in town for the night. But Mike's been stressed out and wants to stay in. No, really, things are going great. We went on a few dates. He's been so romantic. Candles. Music. Every girl's dream. I think my luck has finally changed. Well, I've got something special planned for tonight. I'm gonna show up at his apartment with a surprise he'll never forget. Oh…listen, I'm at his place right now. I'll catch you later. You too. Uh huh. Bye Mike? (*knocks on door*) It's me Suzie. Hello? Oh…uh. The door's unlocked. (*Peeks head in*) Mike? Are you home?

MIKE. Suze?

SUZIE. I stopped by to keep you company.

MIKE. Oh. I'm about to jump in the shower. Just hang out and I'll be done in a sec.

SUZIE. Okay. (*Sits. Wanders. Is bored. Sees that Mike's computer has been left on. Peeks around and listens to him singing in the shower. Moseys over to 'check her e-mail'*) Ah. Customer inventory. Interesting. What sort of tid-bits do you have?(names some random customers and notes on them.) Let's see what happens if we enter in 'Suzanne Moore'. Oop. Here I am. "Suzanne Moore: not exactly what you'd call a model. Ok, but not great. It'd take more of this stuff than she could afford to make her gorgeous." (*sits*) Oh.

MIKE. (*entering*) Hey Suze, what are you…(*sees her staring at the screen*) What are you looking at? Suze, that's nothing.

SUZIE. Oh, it's definitely something.

MIKE. I can explain. Honest.

SUZIE. Men who say honest are usually hiding something.

MIKE. Suzie, it was a joke. Sarcasm. I wrote that as a joke, before I got to know you, before we got together.

SUZIE. Yeah. Absolutely hilarious. (*disgusted look. Exits*)

MIKE. (*knocks on door*) Good afternoon, ma'am. My name is Mike and I'm here on behalf of Lucky You Cosmetics.

SUZIE. Go away.

MIKE. I have just the perfect product to erase unsightly blemishes of personal character.

SUZIE. Do you think this is something funny? I mean, is this just a joke to you? I said go away…now!

MIKE. Look, just give me a minute. Let me explain.

SUZIE. You have sixty seconds.

MIKE. Suzanne, I'm really sorry. It was horrible mistake. I wasn't thinking.

SUZIE. I thought you actually cared for me. I thought you were different than every other guy. Why were so nice then? Was it all just an act?

MIKE. It started out that way.

SUZIE. It what?

MIKE. Don't shut the door, please. I'll be honest it did, but then I got to know you. I got to know your sense of humor, your intelligence, and I began to realize how much you meant to me. Please don't hold one stupid note against me. I swear I'll never do it again.

SUZIE. You're all gloss, Mike.

MIKE. What?

SUZIE. The stuff you sell, Mike. It's all gloss. Powder, glitter, shimmer. It's all a cover-up. Polish to try and make things more appealing. That's all you are – Mike. You're an image. An illusion. A cover-up. The funny thing, Mike. The funny thing is when you wash off all that powder and gloss – what's underneath can still be ugly.

MIKE. Please, Suzie. I'm sorry.

SUZIE. Well I am too Mike because this is one sales pitch I'm not falling for.